



Parasha Va'Et'Channan – Teshuva and Redemption

(Deuteronomy 3:23 - 7:11)

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Parasha Va'Et'Channan, takes its name from Moshe's (Moses) intense plea to Hashem that he be allowed to go over to the goodly land across the Jordan. The Parasha begins with Moshe recounting to Am Yisrael that his pleas, **Va'Et'Channan** ("and I pleaded"), resulted only in the reward of he being allowed to glimpse the land from a distance.

It should be noted, though, that while the parasha takes its name from Moshe's pleas to see the land, it largely is about Moshe's our Teacher admonishing us to cleave to the Torah when we have acquired the goodly land, so that we may keep it. In this sense *Va'Et'Channan* is about a selfless Teacher giving his students an enduring lesson: that they may retain a treasured gift – the heritage of the Torah. The Torah is so identifies in its completeness:

"You are not to add to the word that I am commanding you, and you are not to subtract from it, in keeping the commandments of יהוה your God that I am commanding you."

Devarim (Deuteronomy) 4:2

Our Chakhamim established the practice of reading, on the Shabbat following fast of Tishah B'Av (9th of Av), to read as the Haftarah, Isaiah 40:1-26, which begins with the words: 'Nachamu, nachamu Ami' ('Comfort, comfort My people'). The word *Nachamu* has led to this week Shabbat being therefore called **Shabbat Nachamu**.

Parasha *Va'Et'Channan* and its Haftarah reading (Isaiah 40:1-26) presents parallels to Yisrael who is in languish. As Moshe appeals to Yisrael to cleave to the Torah so that we may inherit the land, there is also an evident reference to an impending *galut* (exile from the goodly land). This stark reality has become evident since the time of the Assyrians, Babylonians, Greco-Romans and others conquest – not only to subdue but, in the cases of some to replace. This makes *Va'Et'Channan* and *Nachamu* – redemptions not just a hope but a sure reality. Since, it must be accepted that if Moshe spoke so clearly about a *galut* that eventually occurred, then naturally so too must be the redemption.

Hence the Chakhamim established that for the *Nachamu* reading should follow the lamentations for the losses of the goodly land, the *Beit HaMikdash* and the goodly things, following a template similar to the path laid out by Moshe in *Va'Et'Channan*. That is:

But when you seek יהוה your God from there you will find [him], if you search for Him with all your heart and with all your being. When you are in distress because there befall you all these things, in future days, you shall return to יהוה your God and hearken to His voice. For a compassionate God is יהוה your God; He will not weaken you, He will not bring-ruin on you, He will not forget the covenant [with] your fathers which He swore to them.

Devarim (Deuteronomy) 4:29-31

Here the Chakhamim point to the pathway laid out in the Torah by Moshe our Teacher – that the sincere *teshuva* of *Am Yisrael* will provide redemption. The direction of the chakhamim in pointing the way of our Teacher Moshe, is evident that, leaving the *galut* should be without the burdens of *chumra* but simple sincere *teshuva*, and Torah. Not coincidentally, **Shabbat Nachamu** occurs mere weeks before the weeks of *Selichots* (the *Teshuva*), again presenting the opportunity of sincere confession, with the hope that the Great Day of Awe (*Kippurim*) will carry after it comforts of redemption – Next Year in Yerushalayim.

The eras leading up to May 14, 1948 (C.E.) was not a concluding point but an opening, for continued catalytic efforts of “*Nachamu, nachamu ami*”. That is, we should therefore urgently continue the efforts to aid *Am Yisrael*, who remain chained by foreign religious dominance in a *galut*. *Va'Et'Channan* – *Nachamu* provide a guide for our Rabbis and leaders to consider, that the path through redemption is one always of sincere *teshuva* יהוה and not through the gates of *chumra*.

Shabbat Shalom